of Reliance, Suneeta Reddy of Apollo Hospitals, or Roshni Nadar-Malhotra of HCL Technologies, the weight of whose legacies must sit heavy on their shoulders. It can often mean having to work twice as hard to prove your merit, so that no one can accuse you of using your privilege.

THE LONG ROAD

The domains they occupy may be different, but the struggles Indian working women face are the same. "Given the stereotypes about women—that they aren't ambitious enough, don't take enough risks, have poor business sense—the biggest challenge as a woman entrepreneur is to establish credibility and access capital," says Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw. Pallavi Shroff, the doyenne of corporate litigation, talks of the unconscious bias women face at work—that they cannot put in long hours, that they are burdened by family responsibilities. Often they end up paying what's called "motherhood penalty", dropping out of the workforce as they marry or have children, circumstances that affect their career trajectories disproportionately compared to the men.

Change, though, is in the air. Inclusivity and diversity are becoming the new buzzwords in corporate spaces. At Diageo India, MD & CEO Hina Nagarajan is aiming to have 50 per cent women in its workforce by 2025. With her boss Mukesh Ambani's backing, Jyoti Deshpande, president of the media business at Reliance, is hiring more women, who now occupy 70 per cent of the leadership positions at Jio Studios. "Unless men are involved in the conversation," she says, "it doesn't work."

Monika Shergill and Aparna Purohit are doing the same at Netflix and Amazon Prime Video. They are reclaiming the narrative for women, and getting them to write their own stories and direct them. Aparna has mandated the writer's room have at least one woman developing a project and 30 per cent women in HoD positions on its titles. Given the access and money that she has, film producer Guneet Monga wants to "put more women through the door because we are companions, not competition".

Manisha Malhotra, the head of sports excellence & scouting at JSW Sports, is doing the same to promote women's participation in sports. "I like to support women also from a performance standpoint," she says. Indian women have a greater chance of being world-beaters than men in several sports is something she believes firmly.

Women have a scant presence in corporate ownership but they are steadily climbing the corporate ladder to take their seat at many a high table

Yet, away from corporate boardrooms, there are domains that remain largely male preserves, say, science or defence, where the role models get fewer. Women form only 14 per cent, 6 per cent and 4 per cent of the air force, navy and army workforce, respectively. It's as lonely in scientific institutions. Women comprise only 26 per cent of India's STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) workforce. What does it mean to be a woman in these predominantly male bastions? Being the only woman in a roomful of men happens all too often, DRDO's Chandrika Kaushik, who supervises the Aatmanirbhar projects for defence, will tell you. The gender bias is as jarring for Padma Priya, director of the National Institute for Research in Tuberculosis. Like Kaushik, she too has found herself to be the only one in the room at the institute where she has worked for the past 23 years.

Among the reasons women are discouraged from studying science is a marital one. Who will marry a girl if she becomes overly qualified? A similar sentiment greeted Nikhat Zareen the day her mother saw her bloodied face after a scrap with a boy in boxing class. Who will marry you? Nikhat silenced her with just one argument—"The day I make a name for myself, boys will queue up to marry me."

Several battles have been won, many others remain. Pay parity, among them. Women in entertainment or professional sport still do not get the kind of dosh their male counterparts do. Deepika Padukone knows something of that struggle. She has had to spend a good number of years in the industry to command the price her male counterparts do. "The minute they see you are successful, they start taking you seriously," she says. The story is no different in sports. Though men and women get paid the same match fees in cricket, the highest grade international male cricketers get Rs 7 crore as annual compensation while their female counterparts get just Rs 50 lakh.

And still they rise. We bring you the stories of a hundred women across varied fields—politics, business, education, the arts, defence, science and sports—who dared to dream, take risks and step out of their comfort zones. On INDIA TODAY's 48th anniversary, we celebrate the growing empowerment of the Indian woman—an irresistible force that waits for no time, tide or man. ■

–with Suhani Singh & Sonal Khetarpal